

The Urgency of Connection in The Face of Crisis

When a city is in crisis, the instinct is to pull inward. That instinct is the problem.

BY TED HEWSON

A crisis does something predictable to a city. It convinces each of us to pull inward — to protect what's ours, work our corner, do what we can with what's in front of us. It feels like the responsible thing, and it is. It's also that exact instinct that keeps a city from solving the crisis at all.

Take hunger. Philadelphia has no shortage of people fighting it. Hundreds of organizations, agencies, congregations, volunteers, and neighbors put in the work every single day to get people fed. Even still, more than 270,000 of our neighbors don't know where their next meal is coming from. Why does the problem persist? It isn't because we aren't trying. It's because too often, we're trying alone.

This is the quiet failure at the center of most community crises. The effort is real, but scattered. Two organizations run the same program a few blocks apart and never compare notes. A family that qualifies for help from one group never hears about the three others nearby. Money gets spent twice on the same need while another goes unmet entirely. People fall through the cracks. Not because no one cares, but because the systems that are supposed to catch them were never built to work together.

We don't lack compassion in this city. We lack connection.

We need to be honest about why that is. When there's scarcity, sharing can feel like risk: your contacts, your donors, your hard-won credibility. Everyone is stretched too thin to add another meeting to the calendar. So we stay in our lanes, not out of selfishness, but out of survival. The problem is that survival, multiplied across a whole city, looks just like dysfunction. What it produces is a community where everyone is working and nothing is changing.

In a crisis, connection isn't a value. It's infrastructure.

Not a conference, a handshake, or a logo on a shared banner. Connection as infrastructure means the relationships that let a pantry call a clinic and get a real answer. It means a funder who can map the gaps because she knows who's actually doing the work. It means a resident who doesn't have to navigate agency after agency alone because the agencies finally know each other. Coordination delayed is help denied. Working in silos isn't just inefficient — it has a human cost, measured in families who need more than any one organization could offer on its own.

That's what drove the 2026 Philadelphia Food Summit on June 5th at Temple University. The idea was almost embarrassingly simple: put the people who never share a room into one. Grassroots organizers and government. Funders and the families they serve. The agencies, the advocates, and the residents living these realities every day. The summit asked one question: *Will you be at the table?* That's because getting to the table is always the first, and hardest, step.

We call it a table deliberately. A table is where trust gets built. It's where a face becomes a name, and then becomes a partner. What happened in that room on June 5th wasn't a conference, it was a beginning. The relationships formed there, the gaps identified, the commitments made across unfamiliar chairs: that's the infrastructure we were actually building.

The summit was never meant to be the answer. It was meant to start one. The real work is what gets carried out of that room and into the weeks, months, and years that follow. The check-in that happens because two people finally met. The program that stops duplicating because two directors finally talked. The family that gets more complete support because the people helping them are finally coordinated. That is what connection, built with intention, actually produces.

A community is only as strong as the connections between the people in it. In a crisis, those connections aren't optional, they're the whole strategy.

The table has been set. The question now is what we build from it, and whether Philadelphia decides that solving this problem together is worth more than solving our piece of it alone.

We think it is. We'll see you at the next table.

Ted Hewson is co-chair of the 2026 Philadelphia Food Summit and a facilitator at Community Connections Collaborative.

The 2026 Philadelphia Food Summit took place Friday, June 5, at Temple University's Howard Gittis Student Center. Learn more at phillyfoodsummit.org — and support the ongoing work at [the summit's donation page](#).